Given this dangerous structural regression, the Bharat Jodo Yatra first and foremost served as a platform for an honest and sincere conversation between the people of India and the political class. Filling the vacuum created by the State, the Yatra paid heed to people's needs and aspirations, and gave voice to the voiceless, as attested by Nikhil Dey's and Medha Patkar-Guddi's essays in this volume. This may seem superfluous, but the Yatra was also an effort to appeal to India's soul. Consciously leveraging karuna (compassion), maitreyi (camaraderie), satya (truth) and sneh (love), the BJY essentially re-humanized and re-personalized India. The cathartic effect this has had on mass consciousness cannot be sufficiently stressed. Even more crucially, in recreating this unique system of mass engagement (that was used to great effect during India's freedom struggle), the BJY acted like a charged magnet traversing India, attracting progressive forces, marginalized and vulnerable groups and ordinary Indians towards it. And millions of Indians came out—from far-flung villages and small towns across India. Representing different things to different people, many normative layers were inscribed onto the Yatra. Some joined the Yatra to express solidarity with what they perceived to be a second freedom movement (as the essays by Dr Ganesh Devy and Professor Mridula Mukherjee–Professor Aditya Mukherjee in this volume suggest) or just to do something meaningful for the nation. Some came to do something bigger than their individual selves (as Sridhar Radhakrishnan's essay suggests in this volume). Yet others came to bless what they saw as a dharmic (spiritual) national pilgrimage, while some were just conscientious bystanders to a grand political spectacle. It is precisely because the BJY was a palimpsest that this volume tries to conjoin diverse voices in a symphony for posterity.

In doing so, like the Athenian historian Thucydides, this volume draws from first-hand experience of the Yatra and then strives to adopt the analytic distance of the historian. It thus analyses the Yatra structurally, mapping its anatomy as well as the why, how and what. In this spirit, *Bharat Jodo Yatra: Reclaiming India's Soul* is divided into three sections. Section one lifts the curtain to outline how this massive exercise was organized and